

Leadership: Standing Together, Healing, and Growing

What Leadership Means to Me

My idea of a leader is someone who stands side-by-side with their people. A leader does not walk ahead of the group; they walk with the group toward the same goal. They use their energy to bring people together instead of pushing them apart.

Often, in schools and in politics, we see leaders who just give orders from the top. They sit in high offices and do not want to do the hard work with everyone else. These leaders usually fail because the group does not feel connected to them. They might have a title, but they do not have the people's hearts. A real leader does not use fighting or fear to get power. Instead, they give power to others by building unity and trust.

I like the ideas in Adrienne Maree Brown's book, *Loving Corrections*. She teaches us that standing together is an action, not just a nice idea. She writes, "We aren't performing solidarity; we are in it together." This quote means everything to me. A real leader is part of the crowd. They are ready to succeed with the group, and they are ready to fail with the group. We often hear the saying "actions speak louder than words," and good leaders show this is true every day. They know that working together is the only way to fix big problems. I believe the best power comes when we are united.

Compassion is Key

To bring people together in a difficult world, we need . Compassion means caring deeply for others and understanding their suffering. I believe a good leader must have a caring heart. A

caring person can understand how others feel and love them, even when things are hard. In a world with so much fighting, anger, and little peace, we need more love and understanding from our leaders.

I learned from Amar Atma's lecture that healing is very important for leadership. To be a good leader to others, you must heal yourself first. This is a hard lesson. Sometimes, it is hard to care for others because we are hurting inside from our past. When we are hurt, we build walls to protect ourselves. These walls make it hard to give love to others. To heal, we must admit we are hurt. This process is called grieving. I believe grieving is the first step to becoming a kind leader. When a leader heals their own pain, they clear the space inside themselves to care for others.

A kind leader can see when others are hurt because they know what hurt feels like. They can understand their feelings without judging them. When people feel seen and loved by their leader, they feel like they belong. This feeling of belonging is necessary for unity. So, being kind is not a weakness; it is the key to being a successful leader.

A Lesson from History

I find deep inspiration in the stories of leaders from Islamic history, specifically the example of Caliph Umar ibn al-Khattab. He was a leader who truly understood that leadership means serving the people, not just ruling over them. He did not stay disconnected in a palace; he wanted to know the reality of his people's lives.

There is a famous story where he walked the streets at night to check on the people. He found a mother with hungry children who had no food. The children were crying, and the mother was hopeless. Instead of just ordering a servant to help, Umar went to the storage house himself. He carried a heavy bag of flour on his own back to the woman's house. When someone offered to carry it for him, he refused. He said that on the Day of Judgment, he

would be responsible for his people, so he must carry the burden now. He then cooked the food for the family himself, blowing on the fire to make it hot. This story matches my view perfectly: a true leader gets their hands dirty and carries the heavy burdens alongside their people.

My Experience: Being a Principal in Jerusalem

I learned the most about leadership when I worked as a school principal in Jerusalem. This is a place that is often full of news about conflict and tension. But for me, it was home, and it was where my students lived every day. It is a place that has seen many crises and deep sadness. Many of my students came from low-income families. They did not have much money, and their lives were very hard. Every morning, they came to school carrying more than just their backpacks. They carried the stress of their families. They carried the fear of the conflict around them. They carried the sadness of poverty. As a principal, I could see it in their eyes. Some were angry, some were quiet, and some were just tired.

Because of the difficult situation in Jerusalem, my students needed more than just books, math, and science. They needed a leader who understood their pain. I used my belief in compassion to help them. I wanted the school to be a safe place—a sanctuary away from the noise and trouble outside.

I made sure to stand with them, just like my definition of a leader says. I did not just sit in my office doing paperwork. I walked the halls. I sat with them during breaks. I listened to their stories of struggle. Sometimes, a student would come to me crying because their family had no food, or because something scary happened in their neighborhood the night before. I did not tell them to "just study." I listened. I validated their pain. I made sure they felt seen and heard.

When a student from a poor family is dealing with sadness and crisis, they need to know someone cares. By showing them love and support, I helped them feel they belonged. I wanted them to know that even if the world outside was chaotic, inside our school, they were safe and loved. This gave them hope. My leadership was about making a peaceful space in the middle of a hard environment. I tried to be like the glue that held our community together when things were falling apart.

Leading Myself and the Lesson of Kintsugi

Moving forward, I want to use these leadership skills on myself, too. I have spent a lot of time caring for others, especially during my time in Jerusalem, but I often forgot to care for myself. I was so busy carrying everyone else's bags of flour, like Umar, that I did not notice my own back was hurting.

I learned a powerful lesson about this through my personal artwork in this class, specifically with the art of Kintsugi. Kintsugi is the Japanese art of fixing broken pottery with gold. For this project, I brought a plate that was very special to me. It was the first plate I ever owned here as a student. It represented my new life and my independence.

To do the project, I had to break this plate that I loved. That was the first hard part. It felt like I was destroying something perfect. Then, I had to fix it. This took a very long time. I sat there for hours, gluing the pieces back together. I had to be very patient. I could not rush it, or the pieces would fall apart again.

As I worked, I realized I could not hide the broken lines. The cracks were there forever. At first, I was frustrated. I wanted the plate to look new again. But the art of Kintsugi teaches us not to hide the breaks. Instead, we mix gold powder with the glue. We paint the cracks gold. We make the broken parts the most beautiful parts.

I tried to make these lines look fabulous, welding my plate with gold. As I watched the gold

lines shine, I realized this plate was like me. The time I spent in Jerusalem, seeing so much sadness and trying to be strong for everyone, left cracks in me, too. I have my own sadness and my own struggles. For a long time, I tried to hide these feelings because I thought a leader had to be perfect.

But this art class taught me that I do not need to be perfect. Like the plate, my scars and broken parts do not need to be hidden. When we treat our wounds with care and "gold"—which is self-love and compassion—they can become the strongest and most beautiful parts of us.

Reading Sonya Renee Taylor's book, *The Body is Not an Apology*, and Adrienne Maree Brown's *Emergent Strategy* helped me understand this even more. Two quotes from *Emergent Strategy* gave me strength: "small is good, small is all" and "never a failure, always a lesson." These words remind me to be kind to myself. I do not have to fix everything in one day. Small steps of healing are good.

I believe leadership works best when we practice it on the outside with others and on the inside with ourselves. I will continue to help others, standing with them in solidarity. But I will also learn to lead myself. I will treat my own cracks with gold, turning my struggles into strength.

References

Atma, A. (n.d.). *Lecture on Grief and Letting Go*.

Brown, A. M. (2017). *Emergent strategy: Shaping change, changing worlds*. AK Press.

Brown, A. M. (2024). *Loving corrections*. AK Press.

Taylor, S. R. (2018). *The body is not an apology: The power of radical self-love* (1st ed.). Berrett-Koehler Publishers, Inc.